For company, when my brothers were away, there was Boris, a Staffordshire bull terrier named after the German tennis player, Boris Becker. We became very tight, after a difficult start.

It was mid-morning at 20 Mentz Avenue. My mother was drying her hair and just a few metres away, aged five, I was sitting on the floor playing with my new canine friend Boris, pulling him, pushing him, wrestling with him. His tail fascinated me, so I turned it, twirled it, twisted it … and broke it in three places.

Boris suddenly snapped and went for me, locking his jaw onto my head, sinking his teeth into my skull. My mother was oblivious to it all because she was looking in the mirror and could hear nothing against the whir of the hairdryer. It could easily have been over and out for the unfortunate five-year-old but, for some reason, my mother turned round and yelled. Boris let go and I escaped with a wound that required 15 stitches.

In such circumstances, dogs are usually earmarked as dangerous and quickly put down but my parents took the view that Boris had been provoked and assured us that he would remain our dog, a great decision.

He became my constant companion.

His favourite game was hide-and-seek. I would tell Boris to sit and wait, and he would stay unmoved while my friends and I ran off and found a place to hide somewhere in the garden.

'Boris,' I would shout, 'on your marks … get ready … go!'

At that moment, he would spring into action and start searching for us.

Beyond my brothers and Boris, I have been fortunate to have three great friends in my life. The four of us met in nursery school, have stayed close ever since, still see each other on a regular basis and, with modern technology, now remain connected on a WhatsApp group entitled '*Oerbuds*', translated as 'ancient mates'. Johan Scheepers, Stoffel de Beer, Chris Swanepoel and me … Skippy, Stof, Chris and AB.